

Summary Guidelines

Year 11 Profile Course with Ms. Fernandez and Josh

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Why Write Summaries?

Learning is a funny thing! On the one hand, we like to say learning happens during class: material is presented and we somehow incorporate it into the mushy mass of connections we call our brains. On the other hand, once we have learned something, it can be hard to reconstruct that process. When we struggle to learn something, we might feel discouraged or frustrated: there is often an indeterminate amount of time before we first really “get it,” and we often struggle to gauge when we have achieved mastery. During a given lesson, we might work with someone else and somehow the act of explaining a concept grants us deeper understanding of that concept. Stranger still, we might find the mere effort required to explain wherein our confusion lies to someone else, whether a classmate or teacher, might lead us to a flash of insight.

Since we are all learning at our own pace in flexible groups, there isn’t a clear notion of “where the class is,” this makes our jobs as teachers a bit different: we want to understand what everyone is working on, what people are struggling with, where people feel comfortable or clear, and what new material needs to be created/found. We just generally want to be as equipped as possible to help each of you, as individuals, learn.

These are just a few justifications for why you are to write a summary each week: one that is to be handed in at the end of every class and will be returned to you at the end of the unit after you show you have mastered the material in an assessment. The summary describes the state of your mathematical learning world (as it relates to what you are currently working on) and how it got to be that way. It is a way for future you (and future incarnations of us, your teachers) to see what went on during a particular lesson, what was difficult for you, what was easy, what you were thinking about, what you were feeling, and, most importantly for you, what setbacks you experienced during that lesson, how they came about, and if/how you overcame them!

This exercise is about building awareness: making your learning transparent. As you’ll hear from us a lot, you get as much out of it as you put in. What you choose to include and what you find helpful will change over time, it’s all flexible! The key is to make future-you clear about how you learned the stuff future-you takes for granted. With all that in mind, let’s go through some examples of what you might include, and leave out of your weekly summary.

What to Include

The general principle of what to include in summaries is: “what information can I no longer access after this lesson is over?” that is really quite a broad field, but let’s just start with some basics in the form of questions:

- **Did you learn any specific definitions or concepts today?** To answer this question it is not enough to just copy down given definition—if you can write the definition in your own words (or with a diagram) it is not only a good exercise, but way more useful (and it allows us to check if things are clear for you).
- **What specific questions did you work on?** What was challenging about them? Which questions did you find easy? What did you do when you got stuck or frustrated? How did it feel to brainstorm? How would you ask the question differently? How would you teach it to a colleague? Your younger sibling?
- **What examples or pictures did you use to grok a given concept or solve a problem?** Just generally draw pictures, its basically half of mathematics.
- **Do you have specific questions about what you are working on?**

What to Exclude

A good rule of thumb is to ask the question “what specific information or impression am I giving either the teacher or my future self with this sentence?” If the answer isn’t clear, or your only answer is the sentence itself, probably best to leave it out.

- **Today we learned about...** General broad sentences help out just about nobody—we all know the general topic and ideas you are learning! You wouldn’t go to a chemistry class and say that you are learning “stuff with atoms” right?
- **I didn’t get...** This is more of a pet peeve than anything, and we will talk about this some other time, but it is important to understand exactly how little this conveys: *no one gets anything initially!* Also, “getting it” isn’t a binary thing that either happened or it didn’t—concepts often have to be digested, they have to marinate... okay enough metaphors, you get it—don’t say you didn’t get something, instead say exactly *what* you didn’t understand and *why*—often just clearly articulating the specific word or idea that you are stuck on will get you unstuck and then, all of a sudden it makes sense!
- **I thought.... was good/bad....** So we know that you are teenagers but we are not your parents so you get to use your full and flowery vocabulary with us!